2026-10-04 Archive RFP 1 ~ Introductory email

Subject: RFP: Archival assessment and master plan | San Francisco | Family + tech-history papers, 1700s–today | Open access, AI-friendly

Hello West_Arch colleagues,

I'm Theo Armour, an architect and software developer in San Francisco. I seek an experienced archivist for a paid collection assessment and archival master plan covering roughly 200 linear feet of family and personal papers, along with artworks, objects, and legacy digital media.

This may be my final design project. My long-term aim is a well-described digital archive, publicly accessible where appropriate.

This initial engagement covers assessment and planning. Please also describe how you would lead subsequent triage, digitization, and transfer to archival repositories, coordinating specialists from your own network. I want to be an excellent client, not the project manager.

The collection runs from the 1700s to today and follows two threads. One is family history, with close relatives including:

- Ambassador Norman Armour, Assistant Secretary of State
- George Armour, president of the Chicago Board of Trade and a founder of the Art Institute of Chicago
- Albert Burrage, who assembled the claims that made Chile’s Chuquicamata copper mine possible
- Walter Lowrie, pioneering translator of Søren Kierkegaard's work into English
- Russian Prince Serge Koudacheff, whose Dutch Masters collection is now being traced by a researcher

The other is my own working life, spanning architecture, software, and cultural institutions:

- Renovating old buildings with a tenant/worker cooperative in South London and swimming the English Channel in the 1970s, then designing 12 Hong Kong subway stations in the 1980s.
- Selling and demonstrating computer-aided design software to highly receptive audiences in China, Taiwan, and Korea, then designing three AutoCAD releases for Autodesk in the 1990s that were prime movers in the change from drafting on paper to designing on computer screens.
- Working with web and open-source communities, Three.js and web-based 3D graphics, and now exploring AI applications in architecture and digital archiving.
- Serving on the board of the Peggy Guggenheim Collection in Venice from 2001 to 2009, and now on the board of the San Francisco Ladies Protection and Relief Society.

The papers include letters, photos, slides, negatives, large-format drawings, and business records, and some of the artworks are museum quality. One favorite: an 18th-century portrait of Empress Elizabeth of Russia, cut from its frame when my family escaped St. Petersburg in 1918.

The attached RFP has the details. Bay Area presence is required for the hands-on work. Proposals are due November 30, 2026. I'm glad to talk, or to show you the boxes, before you submit.

With thanks,

Theo

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